FREE GUIDE · RALEIGH · DURHAM · THE TRIANGLE

The Triangle Home Buyer's Toolkit

Ten mistakes to avoid, two worksheets, a scorecard and the road from offer to keys

01 · 10 costly mistakes

02 · Cash-to-close worksheet

03 · True monthly cost

04 · Home-tour scorecard

05 · From offer to keys



Margarita Cuesta

REALTOR® · (919) 432-2204 · margarita@corralesre.com

BEFORE YOU BUY

Buying in Raleigh, Durham and the Triangle moves fast, and North Carolina does a few things differently from other states. These are the mistakes I see cost buyers the most money, stress and time, with what to do instead.

01 Shopping before you are pre-approved

Sellers here expect a pre-approval letter with your offer. Without one, you can fall in love with a home and lose it to a buyer who was ready. Get pre-approved first so you also know your real budget.

02 Talking to only one lender

Rates, fees and programs vary from lender to lender. Ask two or three for a Loan Estimate, the standard three-page form, and compare them line by line.

03 Missing help for first-time buyers

The NC Housing Finance Agency offers the NC Home Advantage Mortgage with down payment assistance for eligible buyers, and some Triangle cities run their own programs. Ask your lender which ones you qualify for.

04 Forgetting the cash you need besides the down payment

In North Carolina you usually pay a due diligence fee and an earnest money deposit soon after your offer is accepted, then closing costs, the inspection and the appraisal. Budget for all of it from the start.

05 Not understanding the due diligence period

The standard North Carolina offer gives you a due diligence period to inspect, appraise and finalize your loan. You can walk away during it for any reason, but the due diligence fee is generally not refundable. Use every day of it.

06 Skipping or rushing the inspection

A home can look perfect and still hide roof, plumbing or moisture problems. Inspect during due diligence, read the full report, and decide what to ask the seller to repair.

07 Looking at the price instead of the monthly payment

Property taxes change by county and city, and insurance, HOA dues and mortgage insurance all add up. Compare homes by their full monthly cost, not just the list price.

08 Ignoring the HOA rules

Many Triangle neighborhoods have an HOA. Read the rules and fees before you commit: rental limits, fences, parking, paint colors and special assessments can all affect you.

09 Changing your finances before closing

A new car, a new credit card, a job change or large unexplained deposits can delay or even stop your loan. Keep everything steady until you have the keys.

10 Going it alone, or not reading your buyer agreement

Since August 2024, buyers sign a written agreement with their agent before touring homes. Read it, ask how your agent is paid, and remember the terms are negotiable. A good agent explains every line.

02 · CASH-TO-CLOSE WORKSHEET

Cash-to-close worksheet

The down payment is only part of the cash you need. Fill in your lender's Loan Estimate numbers, then the real ones as they come in.

	ESTIMATE	ACTUAL
Down payment		
Due diligence fee (paid to the seller, usually credited back at closing)		
Earnest money deposit (held in trust, usually credited back at closing)		
Home inspection, plus any specialist inspections		
Appraisal		
Closing attorney		
Lender fees and points		
Title insurance		
Prepaid taxes, insurance and escrow		
HOA transfer or start-up fees		
Moving and first repairs		
Cushion for surprises		
Total		

Due diligence and earnest money are due within days of an accepted offer, long before closing. Have that cash ready when you start making offers.

03 · TRUE MONTHLY COST

True monthly cost

Compare homes by what they cost every month, not by the list price.

	HOME A	HOME B	HOME C
Principal and interest			
Property tax (county + city rate × value ÷ 12)			
Homeowners insurance			
Mortgage insurance, if any			
HOA dues			
Utilities: power, water, gas, internet			
Maintenance set-aside			
Total			

Measure the total against your take-home pay, not the most a lender will approve.

04 · HOME-TOUR SCORECARD

Home-tour scorecard

Score each home 1 to 5 right after you see it, before the details blur together.

	HOME A	HOME B	HOME C
Address			
Commute			
Layout and space			
Kitchen			
Bedrooms and storage			
Yard and outdoor space			
Roof, heating/AC and water heater age			
Light and noise			
Nearby shops, parks and services			
HOA rules and dues			
Monthly cost fits my plan			
Total / 50			

Home A · What I loved / what worried me

Home B · What I loved / what worried me

Home C · What I loved / what worried me

05 · FROM OFFER TO KEYS

From offer to keys

01 Get pre-approved

Know your budget and have the letter ready to send with an offer.

02 Sign a buyer agreement and tour

Read it, ask how your agent is paid, then see homes.

03 Make an offer

Price, due diligence fee, earnest money, due diligence date and closing date are all negotiable.

04 Offer accepted

Pay the due diligence fee to the seller and the earnest money deposit into trust.

05 Due diligence period

Inspect, appraise, review the HOA, finish your loan and negotiate repairs. You can still walk away.

06 Final loan approval

You receive your Closing Disclosure at least three business days before closing. Compare it with your Loan Estimate.

07 Final walk-through

Check agreed repairs and that the home is in the condition you expect.

08 Closing

Sign with the closing attorney. Once the deed is recorded, the keys are yours.

You do not have to figure this out alone.

I walk families through every one of these steps, in English or Spanish. Tell me about your plans and I will prepare options before we even meet.

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Margarita Cuesta
REALTOR® · License #358832
(919) 432-2204 (WhatsApp)
margarita@corralesre.com

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